

The First Transcontinental Railroad

Trace the ripples out from the 1869 golden spike: what caused the railroad, what happened right afterward, and what changed for years to come — for whom.

? Historical challenge

On May 10, 1869, two railroads met at Promontory Summit, Utah, and a golden spike joined the coasts by rail for the first time. A trip that once took months now took about a week. But every big change sends out ripples. What caused the railroad, what happened right afterward, and what changed later — and who was helped or hurt?

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Pacific Railway Act (1862) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 1862 law, signed by Lincoln, that funded the railroad with federal land and loans.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the government give the railroad companies?
- Why would the government help pay for a railroad?

SOURCES 2

The Archeology of Chinese Laborers Who Connected the Country (National Park Service)

SECONDARY SOURCE

How over 12,000 Chinese immigrant laborers built the Central Pacific line.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Who did much of the hardest building work?
- Why might their story have been left out for so long?

SOURCES 3

Transcontinental Railroad – Railroads (Library of Congress)

SECONDARY SOURCE

Background and sources on how the two lines met at Promontory Summit.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Where and when did the two lines meet?
- What changed about travel afterward?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

WHAT CHANGED LATER?

Four dashed-line boxes for notes.

WHAT HAPPENED RIGHT AFTERWARD?

Four dashed-line boxes for notes.

WHAT CAUSED IT?

Four dashed-line boxes for notes.

THE EVENT

The Golden Spike – the railroad joins the coasts

May 10, 1869

Promontory Summit, Utah

People / groups affected

The railroad companies — Central Pacific and Union Pacific

Immigrant laborers — Chinese (Central Pacific) and Irish (Union Pacific)

Native nations of the Plains and West

Settlers, farmers, and traders moving into the West

Which result mattered most?

Large dashed-line box for notes.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your ripples with a partner. Which effects did you both list? Which did only one of you find?
- Did you put any effect in a different ring (immediate vs. later) than your partner? Talk about why.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Choose the one result of the railroad you think mattered most. Use evidence from your ripples to explain who it helped and who it hurt.